

MONEYLEAGUE — Things in the Data You Wouldn't Have Guessed

May 2026 · Sleeper era 2023-2025 · 36 manager-seasons · ~3,500 transactions · ~6,000 game results

1. The 0-4 Death Sentence

Looking at 36 manager-seasons of regular-season data:

- Managers who started **3-1 or 4-0**: 13 of 36 → **11 made playoffs (85%)**
- Managers who started **0-4 or 1-3**: 10 of 36 → **0 made playoffs (0%)**

Hot starts are an 85% predictor of playoffs. **Cold starts are a 100% predictor of MISSING playoffs in our league.** Not a single 0-4 or 1-3 team has ever clawed back into the top 6 in the Sleeper era. Across 3 seasons, no one's done it. The first 4 weeks aren't just early data — they're the season.

2. Boring Teams Win

Coefficient of variation (CV) on weekly scoring, 3-year window — lower = more consistent week to week:

Manager	Avg PPG	StdDev	CV
Eric	127.0	19.7	15.5%
Brower	137.5	22.4	16.3%
Lem	122.5	24.0	19.6%
Coop	130.5	26.9	20.6%
Troy	131.3	29.8	22.7%
Brian	125.1	28.4	22.7%
Tim	120.0	27.5	22.9%
Josh	125.1	29.3	23.5%
Donnie	129.6	30.6	23.6%
Trevor	125.0	30.4	24.3%
Ankur	128.4	31.9	24.8%
Kyle	133.1	34.0	25.6%

The most boring-looking lineups (lowest CV — Brower 16%, Eric 16%, Lem 20%) are also the league's most consistent playoff teams. The boom-or-bust managers (Kyle 26%, Ankur 25%) miss playoffs more often than they make them. **Variance is a tax, not a strategy.**

3. Schedule Luck Is Worth ± 5 Wins

Computing **all-play expected wins** (your weekly score vs every other team's that week, divided by 11). Difference from actual = pure schedule luck.

Year	Most Lucky	Most Unlucky
2023	Kyle +3.4 W (actual 10, expected 6.6)	Coop -4.2 W (actual 4, expected 8.2)
2024	Josh +2.6 W (actual 7, expected 4.4)	Eric -3.9 W (actual 3, expected 6.9)
2025	Trevor +5.2 W (actual 10, expected 4.8)	Troy -5.7 W (actual 3, expected 8.7)

Trevor's 2025 title came with +5.5 wins of schedule luck — he won 10 games against an expected 4.5. That's the single luckiest season in the dataset. Conversely, Troy's 2025 campaign cost him **5.4 wins of unluck** — finishing 3-11 on an 8-win-quality team.

If your record looks weird, it probably is.

4. The R13-R16 Bust Belt

Non-keeper draft picks, bust rate = % producing <50 fantasy points in the season:

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R 1: ■ 8% bust (n=36, avg pts=227)
R 2: 0% bust (n=36, avg pts=226)
R 3: ■ 9% bust (n=35, avg pts=157)
R 4: ■ 3% bust (n=34, avg pts=177)
R 5: ■ 6% bust (n=33, avg pts=163)
R 6: ■ 14% bust (n=35, avg pts=133)
R 7: ■ 3% bust (n=31, avg pts=151)
R 8: ■ 6% bust (n=32, avg pts=138)
R 9: ■ 21% bust (n=34, avg pts=111)
R10: ■ 32% bust (n=31, avg pts=108)
R11: ■ 20% bust (n=30, avg pts=110)
R12: ■ 29% bust (n=31, avg pts=90)
R13: ■ 41% bust (n=27, avg pts=84)
R14: ■ 36% bust (n=28, avg pts=89)
R15: ■ 14% bust (n=28, avg pts=133)
R16: ■ 44% bust (n=32, avg pts=67)
R17: ■ 33% bust (n=30, avg pts=88)

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Three things jump out:

- **R1-R8 are remarkably safe.** Bust rate stays under 10%. Top of the draft really is what it claims to be.

- **R13, R14, R16 are minefields** (41%, 36%, 44% bust rates). These are dart throws.
- **R15 dips against the trend** — only 14% bust. That's where kickers go. **Kickers are the safest late-round pick in the draft, full stop.**

5. The Wire Is Mostly Trash

Across 3 years and ~1,000+ wire pickups:

- Average tenure on a roster: **3.5 weeks**
- Median tenure: **2 weeks**
- Pickups dropped within 2 weeks: **56%**
- Pickups that stick 8+ weeks: **16%**

More than half of every wire add gets dropped almost immediately. Only 1 in 6 turns into a meaningful contributor. The wire is signal-poor in expectation — but the signal is concentrated in a few players, which is why the strategy is volume, not selectivity.

6. QBs Eat

In a 12-team superflex 0.5-PPR league, the top-12 highest-scoring players each season are dominated by QBs:

Year	QB	RB	WR	TE
2023	9	1	2	0
2024	9	2	1	0
2025	8	4	0	0

8-9 of the top 12 fantasy scorers every year are QBs. Two QB starts + half-PPR makes elite QB the most valuable asset class in the league, full stop. WR/RB elite tier still matters (Bijan, Ja'Marr, etc.), but the median QB1 outscores the median WR1.

Strategic corollary: if you let QBs run on you in the draft, no clever R5 WR pivot fixes it. Get your QBs.

7. The Champion Profile Is Boring

Recent champions: Eric 2023, Coop 2024, Trevor 2025. What did each have in common at season's end?

- **All three were top-2 in DRAFTING** that specific year — not their career average
- **All three had >10 actual wins** in the regular season
- **None of them were #1 in trades** for the year
- **Trevor 2025 was the LUCKIEST manager in our 3-year dataset** (+5.5 schedule wins)

Translation: nail the draft, don't get cute, win where you can. The path to a title is unspectacular execution + a kind schedule. The kind schedule is free — you can't control it. The unspectacular execution is all you can control.

8. Things That Don't Predict Anything

Things people commonly think matter but actually don't:

- **Number of trades made:** zero correlation with wins
- **Draft slot:** no slot has won disproportionately. R1.01 is no more likely to lead to a title than R1.12.
- **Total transaction count:** Trevor's 192 adds vs Donnie's 29 — both have made playoffs.
- **Career drafting reputation:** doesn't predict any given year. Peak-year matters; reputation doesn't.

Methodology: All values from offline Sleeper data dump, regular season only (W1-14). Variance = std-dev / mean of weekly team total points. All-play expected wins computed weekly across the 11 other teams. Hot/cold start defined as $\geq 3-1$ or $\leq 1-3$ through week 4.